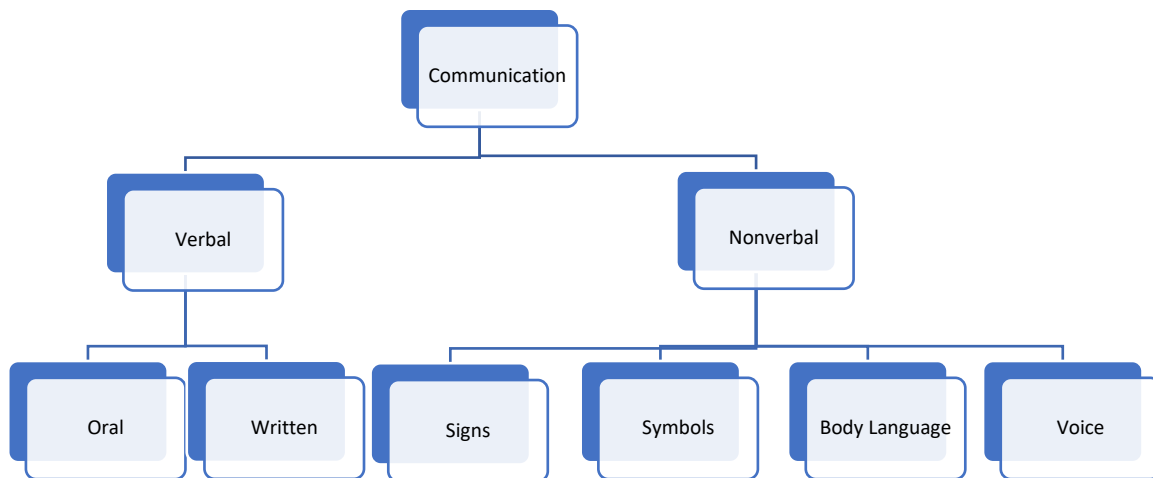


Non-Verbal Communication



People use verbal and nonverbal messages to communicate an idea to a recipient. *Verbal* means “through the use of words” either written or spoken. *Nonverbal* means “without the use of words”. Although major attention and communication study is given to verbal messages, studies show that nonverbal messages can account for over 90% of the total meaning. Nonverbal communication includes meta communication, kinesic messages and proxemics.

Metacommunication- A metacommunication is a message that, although not expressed in words, accompanies a message that is expressed in words. For example, “Don’t be late for work” communicates caution; yet the sentence may imply (but not express in words) such additional ideas as “you are frequently late, and I’m warning you” or “I doubt your dependability” (meta communication). Whether you’re speaking or writing, you can be confident that those who receive your messages will be sensitive to the messages expressed in words and to the accompanying messages that are present but not expressed in words.

Kinesic Messages- People constantly send meaning through kinesic communication, an idea expressed through nonverbal behaviour. In other words, receivers gain additional meaning from what they see and hear - the visual and the vocal:

- Visual – gestures, winks, smiles, frowns, sighs, attire, grooming and all kinds of body movements.
- Vocal – intonation, projection, and resonance of the voice.

Understanding Non-verbal Messages

Meta communications and kinesic communication have characteristics that all communicators should take into account. Nonverbal messages:

- **Cannot be avoided**- Both written and spoken words convey ideas in addition to the ideas contained in the words used. All actions and even the lack of action have meaning to those who observe them.
- **May have different meanings for different people**- If a team member smiles after making a statement, one member may conclude that the speaker was trying to be funny; another may conclude that the speaker was pleased about having made such a great contribution; another may see the smile as indicating friendliness.
- **Vary between and within cultures**- Not only do nonverbal messages have different meanings from culture to culture, but men and women from the same culture typically exhibit different body language. Acceptable male body language might include a handshake or a pat on the back, while women are afforded more flexibility in making body contact with each other (hug each other).
- **Can contradict the accompanying verbal message, and affect whether your message is understood or believed**- If the verbal and nonverbal messages contradict each other, which do you suppose the receiver will believe? As the saying goes by "Actions speak louder than words" provides the answer. Picture a person who says, "I'm happy to be here," but looks at the floor, talks in a weak and halting voice and clasps his hands together in front of his body in an inhibited "fig-leaf" posture. As his verbal and nonverbal messages are contradictory his audience may not trust his words.
- **Provide clues about the sender's background and motives**- For example, excessive use of big words may suggest that a person reads widely or has an above average education; it may also suggest a need for social recognition or insecurity about social background.
- **May be beneficial or harmful**- Words or actions can be accompanied by nonverbal messages that help or hurt the sender's purpose. Metacommunications and kinesic communications convey something like "I am efficient in my business and considerate of others," or they can convey the opposite. They cannot be eliminated, but they can be made to work for communicators instead of against them.

Proxemics- Although there is no general theory to relate posture and position cues to the communications of like-dislike and potency or status, a few concepts of broad relevance are available. The concept of proxemics, or the study of man's use of space as an aspect of his culture shows the distance between a speaker and his listener, the speaker's orientation (that is, the degree to which his body is turned toward, versus away from, his listener), touching and eye contact between the speaker and the listener. Thus, the concept of proxemics subsumes variations in posture and distance and relates to the immediacy of introduction, which is the extent of mutual sensory stimulation between two persons.

Hall used the concept of proxemics to describe the characteristic spatial relationships among persons in various cultures or within a given culture for different kinds of social occasions. However, it is helpful to draw on Hall's observations to qualify the generalization of the significance of proxemic cues. Hall noted that each culture or

subculture holds implicit norms regarding the permissible range of proximity between two speakers. In the case of distance, Hall distinguished four zones: 0 to 1 ½ feet for intimate; 1 ½ feet to 4 feet for personal; 4 to 10 feet for social; and 10 feet and above for public interactions.

Channels of business Communication

Communication channel is the medium or means through which the message sent by the sender travels to the receiver. For example, in Television, you must be seeing and hearing different events on different channels. Channel combines audio signal with a video signal; together and they convey the message to the audience. In radio, channel has only audio signal. Similarly, while speaking or writing, we use a channel to convey a message. Thus, television is an audio-video channel, whereas radio is only a audio channel. There are other channels, such as telephone, voicemail, public address system, Invoice Internet Protocol (VoIP). The choice of the channel in business communication has important ramifications, because if a proper channel is not selected and the message is not delivered in time or it is delivered in a distorted form, business organisation may suffer not only financial losses, its corporate image may also be blurred. In some cases, to ensure clarity, it is a good idea to choose one channel and to follow up with another. Three typical communication channels are:

Two-way, Face to Face (Personal Communication): This is one of the richest communication channels that can be used within and without an organisation. It is particularly helpful because physical presence, body language and tone of the speaker's voice help the recipient to interpret the message. There are no chances of ambiguity as sender and recipient face each other and clarify any point if it is not clear. The speaker can know whether recipient has understood his/her message and can ask the question to ensure it. For example, informal conversations, interviews, oral presentations, speeches and video conferences. It provides instant feedback, the potential to establish a personal connection and information from nonverbal signals. Because of these advantages, two- way, face to face communication can specially be appropriate and effective for conveying sensitive or unpleasant news.

Two-way, not face to face: Two way, not face to face communication includes telephone conversations, online chats and text messaging, all of which provide instant feedback using a real time connection. Often this type of communication is comparably inexpensive form of communication, particularly when communicating over long distances. However, physical

absence creates advantages. Nonverbal elements are lacking, so the message must be particularly clear and forms of feedback and clarification should be used to ensure correct understanding.

One-way, not face to face – This type of channel includes letters, memos, reports and electronic communications such as email, fax, voicemail and web pages, and has the advantage of being considered more permanent and official. Written documents thus are required when legal matters are involved and written records must be retained. However, nonverbal elements and the chance for instant feedback are missing, possible confusion must be anticipated and prevented by ensuring that the message is very well written.

Other forms of communication channels/ directional based channels/Formal channels are:

Downward Communication: The channel used for transmitting communication from top to bottom of the hierarchy in an organisation is known as downward channel. It is sometimes called lower-level communication. It flows from supervisor to employee, from policymakers to operating personnel, or from top to bottom on the organization chart. Teaching people how to perform their specific tasks is an element of downward communication. Another element is orienting employees to a company's rules, practices, procedures, history and goals. Employees also learn about the quality of their job performance through downward communication.

- Policies and procedures
- Organisational goals and strategies
- Work assignment
- Employee development
 - Job role/responsibility
 - Performance appraisal (formal and informal)
 - Constructive criticism
 - Deserved praise and recognition

To elaborate the point, an example may be cited here. The CEO of a company decides to establish a new manufacturing unit urgently and he/she wants to depute the staff from the existing staff temporarily before new recruitments are made. For this purpose, he/she will ask heads of the various departments to suggest the names of the appropriate persons who could be relied upon and could be deputed.

Upward Communication: It refers to the communication by the lower-level workers to the higher-ups in an organization. It is known as upper-level communication also. Upward Communication has following characteristics:

- (i) To make the leader and management aware of the problems and exceptions to set routine.
- (ii) To convey idea and suggestions
- (iii) To make the management aware with the performance of individuals and departments
- (iv) To convey grievances and disputes of the workers.
- (v) To send financial and accounting information, such as cost, payments to be received, interest on investments, levies, etc.

For example, workers in the production department feel that the machinery they work upon has become obsolete and it would be in the interest of not only the company but also for their safety, if the old machinery is replaced by the new one. They would channel their suggestion to the higher hierarchy through their group leader/manager.

Horizontal Communication: Horizontal or lateral communication describes interactions between organizational units on the same hierarchical level. It can be formal or informal, but basic purpose is coordination among different departments in an organization. Horizontal communication may be one of the two types:

- (i) Intradepartmental: These messages are exchanged between members of the same department or division.
- (ii) Interdepartmental: This communication facilitates execution of joint projects in which more than one department of an organization are involved. Horizontal communication has following advantages:
 - a. It improves coordination and understanding
 - b. Free exchange of views
 - c. Time Saver

For example, the marketing department has the possibility of receiving a bulk order provided the quoted price is lowered and the order is complied with on an urgent basis. In this case, head of the marketing department will contact head of the finance department to enquire about the possibility of lowering the price and also head of the production department to enquire about the availability of the said item in sufficient quantity.

Informal Flow/Informal Channel: The *grapevine* often called the *rumour mill* is perhaps the best-known part of the informal communication system. As people talk casually during coffee breaks and lunch periods, the focus usually shifts from topic to topic. One of the usual topics is work- job, company, supervisor, fellow employees. Even though the formal system has a definite pattern of communication flow, the grapevine tends to emerge spontaneously and operates within all organisations. Some of the characteristics of Informal channel is:

- (i) It is fostered through social relationship. No superior subordinate hierarchy comes in the way. A team manager can invite his team-mates to lunch for celebrating success of the project.
- (ii) It is a two-way channel, i.e. both exchange their ideas/experience etc.
- (iii) It does not have a definite path, i.e. conversation is beyond restriction of the organisation and can proceed in multi-directions.
- (iv) There is a possibility of distortion of the communication. It may take the form of rumour also.
- (v) It is a better way of resolving disputes, on many problems cannot be solved through formal channels.
- (vi) It motivates employees, as they feel being given importance.

Advantages

1. Encourages ingenuity: Employees are encouraged to make suggestions and new approach.
2. Increases efficiency: As the employees can freely exchange their opinions, their efficiency is enhanced in solving a problem.
3. Establishes cordiality: In informal communication, personal relations play a major role, which creates mutual understanding and cordiality.
4. Saves time: As it has not to pass through a long protocol, it is fast and saves time.
5. Solution to problems: Before formalising a particular line of action, the management can involve the staff to know their problems, conflicts and complaints and the like. In this way, a mutual agreeable approach may be followed.
6. Induces sense of belonging: As the employees are involved in decision making, they develop a sense of belonging for the organization.

Disadvantages

1. No legal evidence: Informal communication does not have any legal standing.
2. May create confusion: As informal communication does not follow set rules and regulations, there are chances that the intended message is distorted.

3. No secrecy: As the informal communication is finalised after discussing with several people, its secrecy is not maintained. In the case of confidential matters, it is not desirable.
4. Incomplete information: For informal communication, a particular person is not responsible. Under these circumstances, the information may be incomplete. It may cause delay in the execution of the project.
5. Induces irresponsibility: For the mistakes in an informal communication or its incompleteness, a particular person cannot be held responsible. This may lead to irresponsibility on the part of the employees.
6. May cause rumours: As the informal communication does not follow set rules and regulations, people may speculate about it, which becomes a matter of rumours.

Barriers to Communication

Many a time the sender or receiver may come across some noise or barriers during the communication process. They may pertain to the encoding, decoding, interpreting, listening, etc. Barriers may be of several kinds. For instance, if you are affected with emotions, you may not be in a mood or find appropriate words to convey your message. Similarly, if your receiver has a rigid attitude, he/she may not accept your view. If you do not focus on the message, you may not be able to get the complete message. If you're speaking over telephone, you may face network problems that do not allow you to convey/hear the messages clearly. If you do not have adequate language - proficiency, you may struggle to get the right words. If you are ignorant of cross-cultural nuances, you may not be able to understand the message transmitted by people from other cultures. Thus, the barriers may arise because of language/cultural differences, baseless assumptions, emotional instability, rigid mind, confused presentation, lack of concentration, lack of trust, too many transfer channels, inappropriate seating etc.

Linguistic Barriers

The language barrier is one of the main barriers that limit effective communication. Language is the most commonly employed tool of communication. The fact that each major region has its own language is one of the Barriers to effective communication. Sometimes even a thick dialect may render the communication ineffective. As per some estimates, the dialects of every two regions changes within a few kilometres. Even in the same workplace, different employees will have different linguistic skills. As a result, the communication channels that span across the organization would be affected by this. Even when communicating in the same language the terminology used in a message may act as a barrier if it is not fully understood by the receiver. For example, a message that includes a lot of specialist jargon

and abbreviations will not be understood by a receiver who is not familiar with the terminology used. Thus, keeping this barrier in mind, different considerations have to be made for different employees. Some of them are very proficient in a certain language and others will be ok with these languages.

Psychological Barriers

There are various mental and psychological issues that may be barriers to effective communication. Some people have stage fear, speech disorders, phobia, depression etc. All of these conditions are very difficult to manage sometimes and will most certainly limit the ease of communication.

Emotional Barriers

The emotional IQ of a person determines the ease and comfort with which they can communicate. A person who is emotionally mature will be able to communicate effectively. On the other hand, people who let their emotions take over will face certain difficulties.

A perfect mixture of emotions and facts is necessary for effective communication. Emotions like anger, frustration, humour, can blur the decision-making capacities of a person and thus limit the effectiveness of their communication.

Physical Barriers

They are the most obvious barriers to effective communication. These barriers are mostly easily removable in principle at least. They include barriers like noise, closed doors, faulty equipment used for communication, closed cabins, etc. Sometimes, in a large office, the physical separation between various employees combined with faulty equipment may result in severe barriers to effective communication.

Physiological Barriers

Certain disorders or diseases or other limitations could also prevent effective communication between the various channels of an organization. The shrillness of voice, dyslexia, etc are some examples of physiological barriers to effective communication. However, these are not crucial because they can easily be compensated and removed.

Cultural Barriers

As the world is getting more and more globalized, any large office may have people from several parts of the world. Different cultures have a different meaning for several basic values of society. Dressing, Religions or lack of them, food, drinks, pets, and the general behaviour will change drastically from one culture to another.

Hence it is a must that we must take these different cultures into account while communication. This is what we call being culturally appropriate. In many multinational companies, special courses are offered at the orientation stages that let people know about other cultures and how to be courteous and tolerant of others.

Organisational Barriers

As we saw there are many methods of communication at an organizational level. Each of these methods has its own problems and constraints that may become barriers to effective communication. Most of these barriers arise because of misinformation or lack of appropriate transparency available to the employees.

Attitude Barriers

Certain people like to be left alone. They are the introverts or just people who are not very social. Others like to be social or sometimes extra clingy! Both these cases could become a barrier to communication. Some people have attitude issues, like huge ego and inconsiderate behaviours.

However, it is possible to overcome such barriers and make our communication more effective:

- ❖ Know your audience
- ❖ Think before you speak
- ❖ Listen carefully and then react
- ❖ Use appropriate body language
- ❖ Be precise and focused
- ❖ Use right words in right order
- ❖ Be empathetic
- ❖ Avoid too many interruptions
- ❖ Exhibit enthusiasm